

Family Guide: Supporting a Loved One with Depression

Practical guidance for families and caregivers supporting a loved one with major depressive disorder (mdd).

Understanding Major Depressive Disorder (MDD)

Persistent low mood and/or loss of interest lasting two weeks or more, with physical and cognitive symptoms that significantly affect daily functioning.

How to support your family member

Understand depression as a genuine medical illness, not a sign of weakness or a mood the person can simply choose to change. Avoid dismissive statements such as 'just cheer up' or 'think positive,' which can deepen feelings of guilt and isolation. Encourage — without forcing — engagement in activities and treatment, support medication adherence, and take any mention of suicidal thoughts seriously and seek help immediately. Caring for a depressed family member is also demanding, and caregivers benefit from their own support.

Taking care of yourself as a caregiver

Supporting a family member through a psychiatric condition is genuinely demanding. Build your own support network, take breaks without guilt, and seek your own counselling if you're feeling overwhelmed — you can't pour from an empty cup.

When to seek urgent help

Seek immediate psychiatric or emergency care for any suicidal thoughts, plan, or intent, or if depression is accompanied by hallucinations or delusions

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(psychotic features). Urgent evaluation is also needed if a person is unable to care for their basic needs (eating, drinking, hygiene) due to depression.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

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